

# Insulin resistance

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Insulin resistance: Meaning, causes & treatment | Diabetes UK

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Insulin resistance

What is insulin resistance? Insulin resistance is when your body's cells don't respond properly to the hormone insulin. So instead of keeping your blood sugar levels stable and within a healthy range, your blood sugar levels can rise. Insulin resistance isn't the same as diabetes. It can affect people with and without diabetes and at any age but is more common during puberty, pregnancy and menopause. If you don't have diabetes, insulin resistance can increase your risk of diabetes and lead to diabetes if your pancreas isn't able to produce enough insulin to overcome the resistance and keep your blood sugar levels within a healthy blood sugar range. So you may then be at risk of prediabetes, type 2 diabetes or gestational diabetes (during pregnancy). If you have any type of diabetes including type 1 diabetes, you can develop insulin resistance – including resistance to insulin you give yourself, through injections or an insulin pump. Having insulin resistance if you live with diabetes usually means you'll need a larger amount of insulin or medications that lower your blood sugar levels to help you stay within your blood glucose target range. What is insulin sensitivity? You may hear your healthcare professional talk about having a low sensitivity to insulin. It's the same thing as having insulin resistance. It means your body needs more insulin because your body is less responsive to it. If you are insulin resistant and are taking insulin you need higher doses of insulin for the same amount of carbohydrate. This might be your carbohydrate ratio, for example: 1 insulin unit to 10g carbs = higher sensitivity 1 insulin unit to 5g carbs = (insulin resistant) lower sensitivity Causes of insulin resistance You are more likely to have insulin resistance if you have too much fat stored in and around your liver and pancreas, and high blood fats such as high triglycerides, or cholesterol. Insulin resistance is linked to living with overweight or obesity, but it can affect so

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